

Life of the Party

Yancey planned two weeks for his house party. There was the menu, the background music, the party games. And, of course, the guest list. The final decision he had to make was whether to invite his upstairs neighbor Kevin. Kevin was a recluse, a cipher, but Yancey might be the only friend – make that acquaintance – that Kevin had. Yancey was torn. In the end, however, he couldn't bring himself to leave Kevin off the list.

The day came. The guests arrived. To Yancey's surprise, Kevin talked – a lot – and to anyone who was near him. “Did you try the potato salad? It's not too bad. I've had potato salad six times in my life. The first time I was in eighth grade. They told me it was tuna salad, but I knew what tuna salad tasted like, and this was potato salad...” “I don't understand why so many people are wearing sweaters here. I have four sweaters. One of them is blue. I wear that one only when the heat goes off...” Yancey noticed that guests started to avoid Kevin. When that proved impossible, some excused themselves to go to the bathroom and never came back. Finally, groups remembered other engagements, and they left in hordes. In the end, the room was empty, food uneaten, games unplayed, except for Yancey and Kevin. Yancey was incensed. The party he had planned for was in ruins. He turned to Kevin and felt the urge to punch him out. But he knew that wouldn't help. It was no use to clock the darn bore after the hordes have bolted.

